

I have been thinking about the word *exclusive* lately.

What does it actually mean?

Because apparently, in 2026, we need definitions for everything. Are we talking? Are we seeing each other? Are we dating? Are we exclusive? Are we emotionally exclusive? Are we together but “figuring things out”?

Wueh.

Sometimes I think we need a contract just to go for coffee.

But when I think about what exclusivity actually means to me, I don't think it starts with sex.

I think it starts with **access**.

I only really take a man seriously and respect him when I can see that nobody has access to him in quite the same way that I do.

That does not mean he cannot have female friends. Of course he can. I have male friends too. I am not interested in living in a world where men and women are forbidden from speaking to each other the moment they start dating.

But I do believe there is a difference between having a female friend and having a woman you talk to until 2 a.m. about your childhood trauma while telling your girlfriend, “I don't really like talking about my feelings.”

Sir.

Please.

Everybody should not have the same access to you.

The same late-night conversations.

The same emotional intimacy.

The same flirting.

The same attention.

The same vulnerability.

The same little rituals.

The same “I miss you.”

The same soft version of you that somebody could reasonably mistake for a relationship.

I don't want to find out that the intimacy I thought we were building together is something you casually hand out to other women too.

The late-night conversations, the vulnerable confessions, the flirting, the little names and little rituals that made me think, *Oh, this is ours*.

I want to know what we have is special because you treat it like it is special, not because I had to ask you to stop giving pieces of our connection to everyone else.

Intentionality.

This word keeps coming back to me.

Intentionality.

I am not competing for a position in a man's life.

I am paying attention to whether his boundaries already make my place in his life clear.

If you are pursuing me seriously, I should be able to tell there is a difference between how you engage with me and how you engage with other women.

Not because I demanded it.

Not because I gave you a PowerPoint presentation explaining why you should stop giving pieces of our connection to everyone else.

But because you understand it.

Because you want what we are building to be different.

I like a man with boundaries.

A man who respects himself enough to know he does not need to be accessible to all sorts of people.

A man who is intentional with his connections and friendships.

A man who understands that having a lot of people around you is not the same thing as having meaningful relationships.

I like a man with a small circle who knows he does not need to be close to everyone, give attention to everyone, chase a million people, invite everyone over, visit everyone, mix his energy with everyone, or sleep with a thousand girls.

There is something attractive about a person who does not need constant external validation.

And no, I am not saying a man with a large social circle is automatically disloyal, or that a quiet man is automatically a good man.

People can be terrible in complete silence.

It is not about how many people you know.

It is about whether you understand that not everyone gets the same version of you.

The kind of man I find attractive

I like a man who can teach me something.

A man who respects his body.

A man who has goals and follows through on them.

A man who is not afraid of vulnerability.

A man who is not afraid of romance.

A man who shows the world when he cares about something instead of pretending he is too cool to care.

I like a man who knows he is a leader but can lower his guard sometimes.

I want to be able to take care of you too.

I want a man who lets me be myself.

I want someone who can have deep, long conversations without eventually looking at the ceiling like he is waiting for divine intervention.

I talk.

A lot.

Sometimes the story has a story.

Sometimes the story has a prequel.

Sometimes there is an unnecessary subplot.

You will survive.

I want someone curious.

Someone who acknowledges his weaknesses.

Someone who strives to be better.

Someone who treats people with more grace as he grows.

Someone who can be corrected without behaving like I have personally attacked his ancestors.

Someone who can listen to criticism and think, *Okay, maybe there is something here.*

Not someone who hears one uncomfortable sentence and immediately prepares a legal defence.

I want emotional maturity.

Not perfection.

There is a difference.

And I want a man who is not afraid to love.

This might actually be one of the most important things to me.

I want a man who is not afraid of trying.

A man who is not so terrified of failure that he refuses to participate in love properly.

Because loving someone is a risk.

You can communicate and still misunderstand each other.

You can have good intentions and still make a stupid decision.

You can love someone deeply and still hurt them.

You can do your best and still discover that you are not right for each other.

There are no guarantees.

And I don't want a man who spends the entire relationship trying to protect himself from the possibility of heartbreak.

I don't want someone who thinks being emotionally unavailable is the same thing as being strong.

I want someone who can say, "I want this," and actually try.

Try to know me.

Try to understand me.

Try to love me well.

Try to communicate when things become difficult.

And if he gets it wrong, he tries again.

If he hurts me, he can apologise.

If I hurt him, I can apologise too.

If something isn't working, we talk about it.

If something needs to change, we change it.

If we fail, we learn.

Because I don't think love should be about finding someone who guarantees that they will never hurt you.

Nobody can promise that.

I think it is about finding someone who cares enough to repair what they damage.

Someone who is willing to be vulnerable enough to say, *I got that wrong*.

Someone who is willing to try again.

There is something incredibly attractive about a person who is willing to risk looking foolish for love.

Because sometimes loving someone means you will try something and fail.

Sometimes you will say the wrong thing.

Sometimes you will misread a situation.

Sometimes you will think you are doing the right thing and realise later that you were not.

That does not necessarily mean you should have never tried.

I think sometimes we are so obsessed with protecting ourselves from pain that we forget that love requires participation.

You cannot stand outside the relationship with your arms folded, making sure you never become vulnerable, and then complain that nobody ever really knows you.

At some point, you have to come inside.

And maybe that is part of what choosing someone really means.

You are not choosing a guarantee.

You are choosing a person.

You are choosing someone knowing that they are human, knowing that you are human, and knowing that both of you will probably get things wrong along the way.

You are saying, *I still want to try.*

“Men are polygamous by nature.”

This is where somebody will probably tell me that men are polygamous by nature.

I don't know about that.

Maybe there is some biological explanation for why humans desire more than one person.
Maybe there isn't.

But I do know that humans are also capable of making choices.

We have values.

We have judgment.

We have restraint.

We have boundaries.

You can find someone attractive and still choose not to pursue them.

You can enjoy attention and still decide that you do not need it.

You can have opportunities and still say no.

So I am less interested in what somebody tells me men are “naturally” like and more interested in the man he chooses to be.

Because ultimately, I am not dating your evolutionary instincts.

I am dating you.

And I want to know what you do with your choices.

Unfortunately, I am a hopeless romantic.

I think all of this probably explains why I have complicated feelings about dating apps.

I don't judge people who use them.

People have met their spouses on dating apps. People have fallen in love. People have built beautiful families.

Good for them.

May your children hear that story one day and pretend to find it fascinating.



But I don't think I would ever use one.

Maybe I am just a hopeless romantic.

I like stories.

I want to hear, "We met in a matatu."

Or, "We met at a meet and greet."

Or, "We met in the park."

Or, "We met at a bar."

Yes, bar.

Why are we pretending bars cannot produce love stories?

Maybe you met at a playreading session.

Maybe you met at a movie screening.

Maybe one of you was looking for a seat and ended up talking to the other person.

Maybe you initially found each other annoying.

Maybe you had one completely ordinary conversation that somehow became the beginning of your life together.

I like that.

And yes, I know you can meet someone through Instagram, Facebook or TikTok and have exactly that kind of story.

I just think dating apps are a different breed.

Maybe it is because there is something beautiful about meeting someone without already knowing that both of you entered the room specifically looking for a romantic prospect.

Maybe it is the possibility of being surprised.

Maybe it is the fact that sometimes loneliness makes people search for connection in very deliberate ways.

Maybe I am just dramatic.

I am entitled to my opinion.

I want to love someone openly and proudly.

I want to be loved openly and proudly.

I want to make memories without constantly wondering about all the other possibilities sitting in the background.

I want to be the ex someone remembers as the person they experienced life with.

The person they laughed with.

The person they made ridiculous memories with.

The person they were genuinely happy with for as long as they were together.

I want the kind of love R&B singers describe.

I want the stories.

I want the little things.

I want to be able to look back at a relationship and know that we actually lived in it.

So, what does exclusive mean to me?

I don't think exclusivity means you suddenly stop finding other people attractive.

It does not mean you stop having friends.

It does not mean you lose your individuality.

It does not mean you become incapable of noticing that another human being is beautiful.

It means you understand that choosing someone changes the meaning of your access to other people.

You understand that certain levels of emotional intimacy belong inside the relationship you are building.

You understand that some boundaries are not restrictions.

They are protection.

You protect what you value.

And you do it because you want to.

Not because your partner is monitoring you.

Not because you are scared of being caught.

Not because somebody gave you a list of rules.

Because you have chosen.

Because you are intentional.

Because you care about what you are building.

And because you are not afraid to love.

I don't expect a man to be flawless.

I don't expect myself to be flawless either.

Humans will disappoint each other.

We will misunderstand each other.

We will get defensive sometimes.

We will say the wrong thing.

We will have bad days.

We will grow at different speeds.

But if two people are grown and still growing, maybe they can communicate.

Maybe they can repair.

Maybe they can give each other grace.

Maybe they can become better people because they loved each other.

And maybe sometimes they will still fail.

Maybe they will eventually realise that they are not right for each other.

That does not make the love fake.

It just means love is not always the same thing as forever.

For me, exclusivity is not about scarcity.

It is about **discernment**.

It is about knowing that access has meaning.

It is about choosing someone and actually choosing them.

Not halfway.

Not while keeping ten doors open.

Not while giving everyone else little pieces of the intimacy you are supposed to be building with one person.

I want to know that when you choose me, you are actually present in that choice.

And I want to be the kind of woman who can do the same.

Maybe exclusivity is not about having no other options.

Maybe it is about having options and still knowing what you have chosen.

And maybe the most romantic thing someone can say is not:

“I will never hurt you.”

Because neither of us can promise that.

Maybe it is simply:

“I choose you. I am going to try. And when I get it wrong, I am going to try to do better.”

But that is the easy part to say, isn't it?

The harder question is what happens when I am the one who gets it wrong.

What happens when the person I want to be does not quite match the person I actually am?

What happens when I ask someone to be intentional, vulnerable, patient, honest and willing to grow, and I have to admit that I am still learning how to be those things too?

Because it is very easy to write about the kind of man I want.

The harder thing is asking myself whether I am capable of being the kind of woman that man would want to choose.

And that...

is probably a conversation for another day.

Part Two: The Kind of Love I Want to Be Capable Of